

Chapter 10

AI in an L2 translation class

Sonia Vandepitte

Universiteit Gent, Belgium

Teaching translation from the so-called native language (L1) into a second language (L2) requires approaches different from teaching translation into the L1. With the advent of some generative AI tools made freely accessible everywhere, a powerful resource has become available that can be put to good use in the L2 translation class. This contribution will report on such an exploratory class that involved a translation assignment in which ChatGPT was used as an editing tool. It will explain the translation setting and detail the design of how AI was integrated into translation training from a European language into English. It will describe the students' learning objectives and the steps taken to facilitate their paths towards those goals. By illustrating the students' main demonstrated competences, the class design will be reflected upon and some ideas for alternative future classes will be suggested. It will be shown that integrating AI into the L2 translation classroom enriches L2 translation learning, and a constructive critical attitude will be called for.

1 Introduction

Autumn 2022 brought the tool of generative AI (GenAI) to the general public. In a translation training class, this meant that students could now produce translations and edit texts on the basis of the multilingual capabilities of a user-friendly, conversational device which relied on a huge knowledge database. Because it took into account contextual features, its translations in well-resourced language pairs, and especially with the English language, turned out to preserve tone and meaning better than any automated tool before. In addition, its translations of idioms and culture-specific concepts in those languages also proved to contain fewer failures than the previous models of neural machine translation (MT). If



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any organisation could use such a tool, the importance of making students familiar with it in their translation training therefore also became essential.

The next section will review the most relevant characteristics of a training class teaching translation into English as the students' second language, translation in a GenAI context, and some pioneering projects that already integrated GenAI into a translation class from the outset.

2 Literature review

2.1 Teaching translation into the L2

Translation into a second language, i.e. a language which is not the translator's main language, often abbreviated as L2, is often considered to require a higher cognitive load (Krings 1986, Göpferich 2017), although various scholars have demonstrated the high quality of the outcome of such translation processes (e.g. Grosman et al. 2000). Translation training programmes, too, often contain modules with practice in this translation direction. The reason is simple: in many countries there is a need for translation into languages, usually a so-called dominant language or a lingua franca (see e.g. House 2018), for which no translators are available.

Hence, training programmes from the EMT L2 Translation working group (Vandepitte 2023) have collected a set of best practices for teaching L2 translation. First, it was agreed that most students were somewhat less eager to translate into an L2, had less confidence in their abilities, and were more hesitant about their progress than in their translation into their main language.

First, those considerations required appropriate approaches to the general course design. It was suggested that the inclusion of real translation projects (if possible, with extra remuneration for students) worked favourably. If they also include cooperation with fellow class students who can act as bilingual revisers for their first drafts or other students (abroad) who can collaborate as monolingual reviewers because their main language is the targeted L2, students' confidence in their ability to produce a well-written translation is boosted. If students' initial competence varies considerably, or if classes are large, this discrepancy may be identified at the beginning of the course and groups organised in such a way that better-skilled students support others (enhancing students' social skills)

As far as class design is concerned, the following best practices were mentioned as suitable to produce better insight into the translation task ahead. In the first place, much attention should be devoted to text choice. Especially, the relevance, length and topic of the texts have an impact on students' willingness to

start a difficult task. Texts commonly required by the translation market or texts shared by professional organisations are preferable. A topic that is too specific will render the text too demanding and an opportunity for students to observe their own progress will be lost. The teacher can provide specialised glossaries, introduce feed-up sessions, in which both grammatical, lexical and cultural stumbling blocks are pointed out, let the students make a critical analysis of the communicative situation (the translation brief), or organise a class discussion on the domain to which the text topic belongs. Students can receive peer and teacher feedback when first and final drafts are published anonymously on the learning platform, allowing students the opportunity to learn from each other's work.

2.2 Translation in a generative AI context

With the development of GenAI (Eloundou et al. 2023, Felten et al. 2023, Akhtar 2024), translation practices are offered a further step in the automation process. While the use of MT (both statistical and neural) has been amply discussed (e.g. Moorkens et al. 2025), research of the use of a chatbot like ChatGPT (OpenAI n.d., Roumeliotis & Tselikas 2023) in the translation process is still in its infancy. It focuses mainly on the quality performance of the generative tool in comparison to that of MT.

Robinson et al. (2023), for instance, found that the amount of resources in a particular language plays an essential role. Their study involving about 200 languages showed that quality measures in terms of two different metrics of translations with languages for which there is a high volume of resources for GPT models were as high as or equally high as those for traditional MT models. With most languages having a low volume of resources, however, GPT model performance consistently lagged behind. Geng et al. (2024), too, emphasised that non-English large language models (LLMs) can only be developed if available data sets are large enough. Mujadia et al. (2023), on the other hand, report positively on their experiments with translations involving English and 22 Indian languages using LLMs based on Meta's LLaMa.

Other scholarly work on translation by ChatGPT has been carried out in different knowledge domains. Ülkü (2023) focussed on the hospitality industry services that will likely benefit from the use of GPT-4. He predicted that real-time translation by means of the generative model will facilitate effective communication between hotel staff and guests, but did not provide any criticism or caution, nor any data to support his optimistic belief in the translation quality of the tool. Teng (2024) researched the field of poetry translation and comparatively explored faithfulness, expressiveness, and elegance in both a human and GPT-4

translation of a Chinese poem. Cao & Zhong (2023) carried out a statistical investigation to assess the translation quality of a Chinese recipe into English by GPT-4. Drawing on both automatic and human evaluation systems, they found that together with other LLMs, GPT-4 outperformed the fine-tuned MT models and the fine-tuned multilingual encoder-decoder models. GPT-4 created a translation that incorporated cultural adaptations and alternative names for ingredients. Notably, it was more closely aligned with the source text than the human reference text, even though it produced double the number of tokens of the translations produced by the other models. Within the legal area, Giampieri (2024) submitted an English arbitration clause to the GPT chatbot of 2024 and prompted it to translate it into Italian. She reported some lexical inaccuracies and inconsistencies that needed to be post-edited.

In summary, the quality as judged by these preliminary studies, which were not yet available when the decision was taken to integrate GenAI into the class, clearly depends on a number of factors. First, the number of resources available to the generative tool plays a big role, and languages for which there are few resources yield poor AI-tool output. However, for a language pair like Chinese-English, ChatGPT outperformed other MT-models and, in particular, also showed successful translation choices in cultural contexts. Secondly, the text type also has an impact on the translation quality of the generative tool, with legal texts, for instance, requiring special attention to how the source text meaning is rendered.

2.3 Integrating generative AI into the translation class

Including GenAI such as ChatGPT in education has recently been mentioned in various reports as a promising aid to improve students' writing (Cao & Zhong 2023, Labadze et al. 2023, Ouyang et al. 2023), and, in particular, their writing in English as a Foreign or Second Language (EFL/ESL) (Fitria 2023). One advantage of AI-powered chatbots is clear: ChatGPT can provide instant and personal feedback at a time when the learner's mind is set to learn, so that its relevance and impact may be higher than when they receive similar feedback at a later juncture. This will fundamentally change L2 learning: the AI tools will be able to detect gaps in individual students' performances and even give feedback and alternative exercises.

The worldwide availability of ChatGPT towards the end of 2022 also raised *translation* teachers' awareness that the new technological developments after the introduction of CAT tools and the various forms of MT would bring about yet another set of changes to the translation process.

This awareness led to one of the first attitudinal examinations: Sahari et al.'s study (2023) investigated the opinions of both translation students and teachers about the usefulness of ChatGPT when compared with Google Translate. They concluded that students and teachers did not agree on which tool was preferable. However, the AI tool was recognised as a facilitator of typing and spelling, but the tool's results for fine-tuning and double-checking could not be trusted.

Wang et al. (2024) also investigated students' attitudes to the use of ChatGPT in translation. They did so within the framework of the Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology, whose model points at factors influencing participants' attitudes. They found that despite a positive attitude towards ChatGPT, students still commonly used MT systems.

Gao (2024) describes a pilot programme, in which the texts of political speeches were submitted to ChatGPT 3.5. The translations produced were discussed by the students and compared to translations produced by professional UN translators. They found that the GPT model was successful in producing first draft translations with appropriate lexical and grammatical information. However, it was not yet capable of sufficiently dealing with complex linguistic, cultural, ideological or other contextual nuances.

Cao & Zhong (2023) produce statistical evidence for the usefulness of ChatGPT in the context of a translation class. They carried out an analysis of translations submitted by Chinese ESL/EFL learners and compared both the overall quality (measured using BLEU scores) and some linguistic features (Coh-Metrix) of three types of student translations of a short press release: some translations only underwent self-feedback, others elicited teacher feedback, and a third set received feedback by ChatGPT. The results of this analysis indicated higher BLEU scores and syntactic Coh-Metrix scores for the translations produced after teacher feedback and the lowest score was given to the GPT feedback generated translations. Translations with ChatGPT feedback only scored better in the lexical domain. They suggest that ChatGPT "relies on replicating patterns from its training data rather than performing true syntactic analysis, thereby failing to offer substantive feedback" (Cao & Zhong 2023:13).

While Gao's program integrated GenAI into the translation class process as a tool that is prompted to perform the translation itself, Cao and Zhong designed a process in which the tool is requested to act like an educator and to provide feedback to the students' translations.

The following sections will describe and discuss an exploratory course which integrated ChatGPT into the students' translation process in yet another way. This course from a European EMT translation programme in Spring of 2023 had students translate into an L2, a task in which students could benefit if they

could access the opinions of a target language speaker. The course therefore had students use ChatGPT as a monolingual reviser of their own translation work.

3 Course design for ChatGPT in an L2 translation class

As mentioned above, the course reported here had students use a GenAI tool, mainly for editing. The course was part of a Master's translation programme and required students to be able to translate from their L1 into English as an L2. The use of the AI-tool at the revision/review stage of their translation process would therefore give them more confidence about the choices they had made in their L2 text production. The class included 28 students, and although English is not the only L2 in their programme, their level of English proficiency can be described as C1-C2.

At the time of submitting course descriptions, GenAI had not yet become publicly accessible and was therefore not included in the course description. Hence, it was a primary ethical and legal requirement of the course design to assess whether the set of learning objectives already identified in the course description contractually allowed for the introduction of AI into this final-year master's course. It turned out that the most general learning objective, *acting in an unpredictable and complex context*, and the learning objective including the appropriate methods applied during the student's individual cognitive translation process, *applying the appropriate digital (reference) tools*, made it possible to include an exercise with GenAI.

At the start of the course, before some of the research reviewed above was published, few students had heard about GenAI, which they would become more familiar with in their compulsory language technology module of the programme. In order to introduce them very quickly to the GenAI tools, the students were presented a straightforward list with direct AI website links from which they could choose one, including ChatGPT-3.5, Perplexity and Jasper. There was also a reference to future developments such as Meta's Llama and Google Gemini.

The student's use of a generative tool was integrated into their translation process as follows. First, students were asked to translate a passage from the source text and place it on the course collaboration platform. Second, they were asked to revise and review a team partner's translation independently. Third, the original translator would submit the edited translation to an AI-tool, asking it to improve the text or giving it another prompt of their choice, and pasting the outcome underneath the edited translation. Finally, they would compare the AI tool version with the revised translation and indicate any differences with

an annotation; they would put a + sign in the balloon if they agreed with the proposed change or write an alternative solution, if they did not agree with the AI tool version.

Similarly to previous non-AI translation processes, students were reminded to adopt a frame of mind that is similar to that of a reader of the target text (in this case, a foreign student, see below) and to ask themselves what expectations the typical target reader might have in terms of register and terminology. They were also reminded to interpret the source text as well as possible, and to be aware of spelling, layout, grammar and terminology.

As a result, students' work would look as follows. Figure 1 shows the first draft submission of a student and the two editing comments made by their peers, one of which has been complemented with a teacher comment.

CHAPTER VII. DISCLOSURE OF THE OVERVIEW OF DECISIONS AND THE REPORT FOR NON-MEMBERS

Article 28

No later than 5 working days after the relevant meeting, the overview of decisions is published by the secretariat of the Board of Governors on the intranet of Ghent University.

On the first working day after the approval of the draft report by the Board of Governors or the Executive Board, the final report is published by the secretariat of the Board of Governors on the intranet of Ghent University.

If necessary, the confidentiality of one or more of the decisions made by the Board of Governors or the Executive Board is taken into account when disclosing the overview of decisions and the report for non-members.

CHAPTER VIII. RIGHT OF INSPECTION

Article 29

The members of the Board of Governors or the Executive Board are entitled to a reciprocal right of inspection in the confidential or non-confidential reports and preparatory documents. This right of inspection also relates to the files covered before the directorship of a member, when relevant for the assessment of the files presented to the administrative body during the term of office.

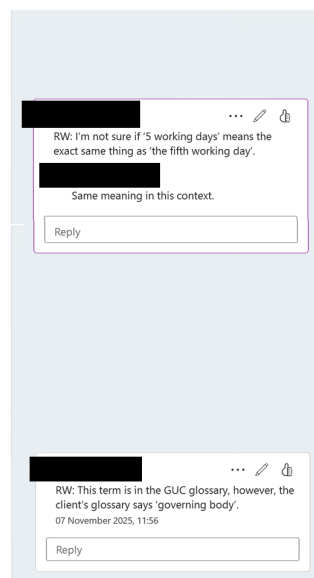


Figure 1: A student's first draft translation with peer and teacher feedback.

Figure 2 illustrates the GPT-3.5 output of an editing prompt given by the original translation student and her own annotated comments with pluses or alternative solutions.

Further noteworthy details of the translation setting in this course are the following. First, a real-world client was involved: the university's legal office needed a translation of its University Codex from the students' main language into English. This source text meant that legal language was involved and their

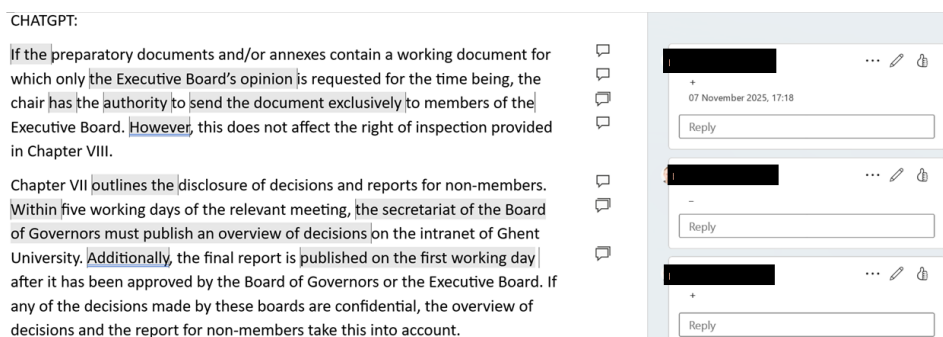


Figure 2: The GPT-edited version of the peer-revised draft (from Figure 1) with the translating student's comments.

target audience consisted of foreign staff and students. Since this translation setting included a paying client, students would also be remunerated (with book tokens) for their extra translation work. In addition, the client was available for any questions that might arise relating to the translation and students would, hence, be able to practice client communication. For this purpose, a working document was prepared, called 'Questions to the client', in which students could write about their translation problems. This document was discussed in class and questions that were retained for referral to the client were collected and sent by the teacher. Each communication from the client was then also provided to the whole class in the same document. The students could further consult both a parallel and comparable corpus and glossaries, which had been compiled in previous classes for translations for the same client and the same target text.

Finally, as in other L2 translation classes, students were able to work on a student collaboration platform, in which each student's contribution was visible relatively anonymously to everyone.

All materials provided by the students who participated in this project have received student consent for research purposes and may be used to illustrate what the students were capable of in this pilot project.

4 Findings

First, students did not do much experimentation with a variety of GenAI tools but only applied ChatGPT and only used it in their revision process. It also turned out that some students confused Machine-Translated texts with AI-generated texts and referred to, for instance, Deep-L, which was already familiar to them. However, students did not prompt ChatGPT to produce a translation.

More importantly, students were able to identify differences between the translation version that had undergone monolingual and bilingual revision by their peers and the text as edited by the GenAI tool used. In particular, they were not only able to identify better formulations in the L2, but also unwelcome omissions, additions, and even (sometimes minor) differences of meaning between their own versions and the ones provided by ChatGPT.

The following set of examples shows that students largely agreed with ChatGPT improvements. They involved the more idiomatic use of the Anglo-Saxon genitive (less frequently used in their own native language) (1), the avoidance of a split *to*-infinitive construction (2) and the use of the active rather than the passive voice (3):

- (1) a. Peer-revised draft
*an opinion **by the Executive Board** is requested*
 b. GPT-edited version
*the **Executive Board's** opinion is requested*
 c. Student comment
 +
- (2) a. Peer-revised draft
*the chair can decide **to exclusively send** the document to members of the Executive Board*
 b. GPT-edited version
*the chair can decide **to send the document exclusively** to members of the Executive Board*
 c. Student comment
 +
- (3) a. Peer-revised draft
*the overview of decisions **is published by** the secretariat of the Board of Governors on the intranet*
 b. GPT-edited version
*the secretariat of the Board of Governors **must publish** an overview of decisions on the intranet*
 c. Student comment
 +

The next set of examples (4–6) illustrates students' recognition of undesirable addition and omission as provided by ChatGPT:

(4) a. Peer-revised draft

The Internationalisation Council creates a policy plan regarding internationalisation (Integrated Policy Plan) evaluates and guides the implementation of this policy in cooperation with all parties involved. All themes regarding internationalisation can be discussed. Regarding the educational and research related aspects within the themes, the Internationalisation Council shall seek advice from the Educational Council and Research Council, respectively.

b. GPT-edited version

INTERNATIONALISATION COUNCIL

The Internationalisation Council develops a plan for internationalisation (the Integrated Policy Plan) and ensures that it is implemented with input from all relevant parties. The Council addresses all aspects of internationalisation, and seeks input from the Educational Council and Research Council on related issues.

c. Student comment

title is not necessary

(5) a. Peer-revised draft

The Internationalisation Council creates a policy plan regarding internationalisation (Integrated Policy Plan) evaluates and guides the implementation of this policy in cooperation with all parties involved. All themes regarding internationalisation can be discussed. Regarding the educational and research related aspects within the themes, the Internationalisation Council shall seek advice from the Educational Council and Research Council, respectively.

b. GPT-edited version

The Internationalisation Council develops a plan for internationalisation (the Integrated Policy Plan) and ensures that it is implemented with input from all relevant parties. The Council addresses all aspects of internationalisation, and seeks input from the Educational Council and Research Council on related issues.

c. Student comment

a lot of text is left out, which I wouldn't do in a text like this

(6) a. Peer-revised draft

*The secretary registers the application, indicating the member and, if applicable, the reasons for the application, **retrieves** the file or the information and grants access to the applicant.*

b. GPT-edited version

The secretary will record the request, including the name of the member and the reasons for the request, if applicable. The secretary will then grant access to the requested files or information.

c. Student comment

'retrieves' is omitted

Notably, meaning differences, even minor ones, have been identified and rectified by students. Examples (7-8) show that the student is able to rely on the information from the co-text to interpret the source text as intended:

(7) a. Peer-revised draft

*The secretary registers the application, indicating **the member and, if applicable, the reasons for the application**, retrieves the file or information and grants access to the applicant.*

b. GPT-edited version

*The secretary will record the request, including **the name of the member and the reasons for the request, if applicable**. The secretary will then grant access to the requested files or information.*

c. Student comment

positioning of the original translation better as in this version [=GPT's] it could be interpreted as both the member and the reasons are only registered if applicable

(8) a. Peer-revised draft

Members with an advisory vote :

- *the environmental coordinator*
- *the sustainability policy officer (secretary)*
- *experts in sustainable energy, mobility, purchasing, food, education, and research (present depending on the agenda)*

b. GPT-edited version

*Members with an advisory vote **include** :*

Environmental coordinator

Sustainability policy officer (secretary)

Experts in sustainable energy, mobility, purchasing, food, education, and research (present depending on the agenda)

c. Student comment

'include' implies that there are also other members with an advisory vote

Although example (9) shows that the student did not have the complete information about university faculties, which the teacher comment makes clear, they did see a meaningful difference with the first draft, which happened to render the situation as intended by the client:

- (9) a. Peer-revised draft
Three assistant academic staff representatives, of which one from the alpha, one from the beta, and one from the gamma faculties
- b. GPT-edited version
Three assistant academic staff representatives, one from each of the alpha, beta, and gamma faculties
- c. Student comment
I would not adopt this phrasing as it seems like there are multiple alpha, beta and gamma faculties
- d. Teacher comment
There are multiple alpha, beta and gamma faculties, but not each faculty is represented on the Council, which the ChatGPT version implies

Apart from identifying better or worse alternatives, students were also able to suggest better formulations, as, for instance in example (7) above or (10–11) below:

- (10) a. Peer-revised draft
CHAPTER VII. DISCLOSURE OF THE OVERVIEW OF DECISIONS AND THE REPORT FOR NON-MEMBERS
Article 28
No later than 5 working days after the relevant meeting, the overview of decisions is
- b. GPT-edited version
***Chapter VII** outlines the disclosure of decisions and reports for non-members. Within five working days of the relevant meeting, the secretariat*
- c. Student comment
this is a title so a verb is not necessary
- (11) a. Peer-revised draft
Composition

Chair: rector or vice-rector

Voting members, in addition to the chair:

- *the chief logistics administrator*
- *the Director of Administrative Affairs*
- *the Director of Infrastructure and Facility*

b. GPT-edited version

Composition: The committee is chaired by the rector or vice-rector and consists of voting members and members with an advisory vote. Voting members include

- *Chief logistics administrator*
- *Director of Administrative Affairs*
- *Director of Infrastructure and Facility*

c. Student comment

I would keep the original structure as this wording is longer and not really necessary for clarity

5 Discussion

This descriptive exploration of an L2 translation course in which GenAI has been included in the editing stage of the translation process has shown that students are able not only to identify differences, but also to assess them in terms of desirability. They did so at various language levels: grammar, sentence structure, layout and, importantly, also at the textual level, which seemed to pose some difficulty to ChatGPT. Such behaviour testifies to their level of competence in the L2 language, their awareness of client-intended content matter from a legal domain and their ability to use GenAI as a revision tool. It was also shown that students are able to suggest better formulations to ChatGPT itself, and therefore improve the GenAI tool by providing feedback.

This does not mean, however, that all student comments or assessments were appropriate. Other observations revealed that students may wrongly identify ChatGPT suggestions as better alternatives, or, vice versa, wrongly determine that ChatGPT's different formulations were undesirable. The latter could be seen as cases of hyperrevision (Robert et al. 2018) and the undesirable imposition of one's own style onto the target text, as when a student changes *within 5 working days* to *no later than the fifth working day*. Unless such a change is made on the basis of explicit rules about consistency of certain phrases, it may be due to the higher frequency of a particular phrase in a student's mental lexicon.

In terms of the students' learning objectives, the course design integrating ChatGPT offered the students ample practice in exploring a changing environment and digital tool use. In addition, the GPT input also provided alternative phrasings which may stimulate their creativity in the L2 and contribute to their command of English and language sensitivity. The presence of an additional touchstone for their own work may also boost their sense of independence.

Students further practised the skill of underpinning their views on the desirability of translation solutions (an essential post-editing skill) and communicating about them, even to the client. In her final communication, the latter, for instance, repeated her words of gratitude for the student comments and the depth of reading that they had demonstrated, even across different regulations, which had led to better regulations for the university.

However, the course design did not give the students the opportunity to compare different generative writing tools or to practice various prompts as Viđakovic (2023) or Giampieri (2024) recorded. A comparative exercise of different translations and revisions by the same tool may already stimulate a valuable class discussion on the desirability of translation solutions, as the two translations by ChatGPT from March 2024 show in the following boxes (underlined phrases show passages where the two texts differ).

LLM Response 10.1:

Tom Lanoye receives prestigious Prize of Dutch Literature 2024 This autumn, the Flemish writer Tom Lanoye will be honored with the Prize of Dutch Literature. Flemish Minister of Culture Jan Jambon (N-VA) announces this on behalf of the Committee of Ministers of the Language Union. Lanoye is the first Flemish author since 2012 to receive the triennial prize. Following in the footsteps of renowned figures like Hugo Claus and Jeroen Brouwers, the Flemish writer Tom Lanoye is now also awarded the Prize of Dutch Literature. This is the most important literary prize in the Dutch-speaking area. The prize, which comes with a cash amount of 60,000 euros, is awarded every three years by a jury of critics, academics, and authors. The jury members always seek an author whose work holds a significant place in Dutch-language literature. "Tom Lanoye uses the theatricality of literature in all its forms to express himself about the real world," says the jury in its report. "It is this baroque, language-virtuoso, yet equally serious interpretation of literary engagement that

we are pleased to honor.” Who is Lanoye? Tom Lanoye was born in 1958 in Sint-Niklaas but currently lives and works alternately in Antwerp and Cape Town. As a novelist, poet, columnist, screenwriter, and playwright, he is one of the most read and praised authors in the Netherlands and Belgium. Giel Bosmans

Can you give an alternative translation for the same text?

LLM Response 10.2:

Tom Lanoye to be awarded prestigious Dutch Literature Prize 2024 This fall, Flemish author Tom Lanoye will be honored with the Dutch Literature Prize, as announced by Flemish Minister of Culture Jan Jambon (N-VA) on behalf of the Committee of Ministers of the Language Union. Lanoye is the first Flemish writer since 2012 to receive this triennial award. Following in the footsteps of literary giants such as Hugo Claus and Jeroen Brouwers, Tom Lanoye, the Flemish author, is now set to receive the Dutch Literature Prize, the most esteemed literary award in the Dutch-speaking region. The prize, carrying a monetary reward of 60,000 euros, is bestowed every three years by a panel of critics, academics, and authors. The jury consistently seeks an author whose work occupies a significant position in Dutch-language literature. The jury’s report states, “Tom Lanoye utilizes the theatricality of literature in all its facets to comment on the real world. It is this baroque, language-virtuoso, yet equally serious embodiment of literary commitment that we are delighted to recognize.” Who is Lanoye? Born in 1958 in Sint-Niklaas, Tom Lanoye currently resides and works alternately in Antwerp and Cape Town. Renowned as a novelist, poet, columnist, screenwriter, and playwright, he stands as one of the most widely read and acclaimed authors in both the Netherlands and Belgium. Giel Bosmans

A comparative analysis of the output of different generative tools, too, will present an opportunity for an in-depth class discussion on translation processes. While GPT-4 (OpenAI 2024) only rendered a translation, Google’s Gemini (2024), for instance, added comments to its translation of a passage from the students’ source text:

- (12) The translation aims to accurately convey the meaning of the original Dutch text. However, nuances in language and cultural context might not be fully captured. For more specific or legal interpretations, it is always recommended to consult with a legal professional familiar with Belgian law and university governance.

[...]

“Bestuurders” has been translated as “governors” to reflect the role of these individuals in the university’s governance.

“Raad van Bestuur” and “Bestuurscollege” have been translated as “Board of Governors” and “Executive Board” respectively, based on common English terms used in university governance.

The phrase “maatschappelijk geëngageerde” has been translated as “socially engaged” to convey the university’s commitment to societal issues.

(Google 2024)

Nor did the course design include any evaluation stage of the students’ individual use of ChatGPT, which is an important stage of the student learning process. Our complex and ever-changing world will need translators to be able to translate texts themselves, performing all the traditionally required cognitive writing processes, as well as to post-edit a GenAI-tool.

6 Conclusion

To conclude, integrating AI into the L2 translation classroom with a real-world task not only responds to the call of leaders at all levels of government to introduce AI into teaching in order to maintain global competitiveness. It also facilitates the road to reaching basic learning objectives, and, therefore, enriches L2 translation learning in a way that enhances reflective thought. The latter may in itself increase intrinsic motivation, a focal point in much L2 translation training.

Considering the importance of the role of GenAI in education (Labadze et al. 2023), this exploratory project recommends the critical application of a GenAI-tool to be added as an additional learning objective in future L2 translation courses. It further shows teachers the direction in which the course design could be improved. In order to retrieve all the relevant information, students can be given a template for their assignments with space for their first draft of the translation, the monolingual and bilingual revision of that draft, a screenshot of students’ prompts showing the generative tool used, an AI chatbot output with students’ comments, and a final conclusion on the comparison between the revised

version and the AI chatbot output (including the number and type of changes accepted/ignored and whether they would use the tool again). Devoting course time to explore different translation-generative tools and to discuss their output is also recommended.

While this qualitative inquiry has only focused on just one aspect of using AI in translation training, other teaching implications have been left undiscussed: ways in which a chatbot can help the teacher set up an examination text on a topic from texts seen in class or design a schedule for peer collaboration in large groups.

However, as Gao writes: “GPT is not, and will not be, an adequate substitute for the language expertise, cultural awareness, ideological sensitivity, and creative abilities to ‘re-write’ on the part of professional human translators” (2024:1). Therefore, the training of a constructive while at the same time critical attitude towards GenAI is essential, perhaps more strongly than ever before. This should keep the standards of academic integrity and increase awareness of local and international ethical and legal issues. Today, courts have decided that AI systems do not have any rights, nor do they have a legal personality (which is reserved for natural and juridical persons). Nor will AI systems ever show true intelligence (Chomsky 2023). The main problem with them derives from the fact that they are solely based on a volume of data and algorithms that apply to that volume and were provided by often unidentifiable humans. In spite of GPT’s recently implemented measures for bias reduction and content moderation, that volume may still contain bias, toxic language or other harmful content. Better training and more reliable data sources will not completely stop an AI-tool from yielding hallucinations or responses that do not mirror true facts, nor will protection measures be foolproof against malicious actors. In other words, quality control will remain an ongoing effort that users need to be aware of.

In order to build the necessary constructive critical attitude, various roads can be taken by translation trainers. They can provide for a creative skills module in the translation curriculum (Guerberof Arenas & Asimakoulas 2023), they can make their students aware of sustainability issues in the evaluation of the technology they use (Moorkens et al. 2024), and/or they can attribute human-centred augmented intelligence (O’Brien 2024) a central place in their own course.

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